

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Psychological thriller

DIRECTOR

Martin Scorsese

WRITER

Paul Schrader

STARS

Robert De Niro, Jodie Foster, Cybill Shepherd, Harvey Keitel

BEFORE

1973 Martin Scorsese, Robert De Niro, and Harvey Keitel team up for the first time with *Mean Streets*, the story of a low-ranking New York mobster.

1974 De Niro shoots to fame in *The Godfather: Part II*, as the young Don Vito Corleone.

AFTER

1982 Scorsese directs De Niro in *The King of Comedy*, a black comedy about another delusional New York loser.

1990 Scorsese returns to the mob with *Goodfellas*, one of his most popular movies.

It is 1976, and there are around 7.8 million people living in New York City. Travis Bickle (Robert De Niro) regards them all through the filthy windows of his cab—everywhere he looks, from Times Square to East 13th Street by way of Park Avenue South, there are people, but to Travis they may as well be characters in a movie. He is an outsider, alienated and angry, who views the world from the inside of a car. This is the taxi driver of Martin Scorsese's movie, who drifts through the city in a clammy fever dream.

Cleansing rain

Taxi Driver is a dirty movie, not in the same way as the porn movies that Travis likes to watch in the run-down theaters of 42nd Street, but in its depiction of the grimy city. Scorsese shot the movie in the summer heat wave of 1975, during a trash-collection strike that left Manhattan mountainous with rotting garbage. "Thank God for the rain to wash the trash off the sidewalk," says Travis. "Someday a real rain will come and wash all this scum off the streets."

In Travis's world, the only clean things are his conscience and his driving licence. To him, everything else is disgusting, including his fellow New Yorkers. He finds them

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The immediate response is usually very visceral and angry. But if this film weren't controversial, there'd be something wrong with the country.

Paul Schrader

Interview with Roger Ebert,
Chicago Sun-Times, 1976

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degenerate, railing against prostitution, homosexuality, and drug taking. When Travis talks about a cleansing rain, he means it biblically, apocalyptically. But he is not a religious fanatic—he just wants a purpose. His God exists only to give him the order to kill, just as his commanding officer did when Travis served as a marine in the Vietnam War.

Lost soul

Travis is lost in so many ways: he fought on the losing side in the war in Southeast Asia, and now

Minute by minute

